

Thematic Analysis: Collaborative Meal Preparation Interviews (Round 2)

Participants: Participant 2A, Participant 2B, Participant 2C Method: Inductive thematic analysis across the Planning, Cooking, and Sharing/Eating stages

Theme 1: There's no real coordination system, roles just happen in the moment

All three participants described basically the same pattern. Nobody sits down beforehand and decides who's doing what. Instead, someone starts giving instructions on the spot, or the most experienced cook ends up taking charge by default, while everyone else waits to be told what to do.

Participant 2A: "there's no real system for us, but there must be someone who is the most familiar one with the dish. So... he will be the head chef, I guess, and everyone else will just stand around to wait to be told."

Participant 2B: "we don't really have a proper system... one person just starts telling everyone what to do... if nobody takes in charge, then someone else will just wait around for a bit."

Participant 2C: "we do not really assign everything properly before we start."

This suggests coordination isn't missing because people don't want structure. It's missing because nobody sets it up in advance. It gets improvised halfway through cooking instead.

Theme 2: Whoever knows the recipe ends up doing most of the work

A pretty striking overlap here. Whoever is most confident or knowledgeable about the dish ends up carrying most of the labour, while others contribute less.

Participant 2A: "I'm always the one who know all the recipe, so I'm doing 90% of the work... it feels like I'm running a restaurant instead of cooking with them."

Participant 2B: "If I'm the one who suggested the meal, I might end up doing the most of the prep and cooking. Then someone else only does one small thing."

Participant 2C, on cleaning specifically: "one person ends up washing most of the dishes because they cannot stand seeing the sink full."

All three frame this as genuinely unfair, not just inconvenient. It's more of an emotional cost than a pure efficiency problem.

Theme 3: Small kitchens and limited equipment make things worse

Cramped kitchens, one working pan, a slow stove, a tiny sink. These physical constraints kept coming up as a separate but related source of chaos, on top of the coordination problems.

Participant 2A: "we only have one decent frying pan and a electronic stove where we can only have two hot plates that actually work... we keep bumping into each other."

Participant 2B: "The kitchen here is quite small, so three of us were moving around at the same time... We kept getting in each other's way, and the electric stove is quite slow, so some food was done earlier than the rest."

Participant 2C: "The chicken took longer than we expected, but the pasta was already done, so we were trying to keep one thing warm."

Timing mismatches aren't just bad planning then, they're partly baked into sharing an under-resourced kitchen. Any solution needs to work with those real constraints rather than assume an ideal kitchen setup.

Theme 4: Sharing recipes mid-cook through a phone doesn't really work

All three brought up almost the exact same scenario. Hands are covered in oil or sauce, the phone screen is locked, and the recipe is stuck on someone's device. People end up shouting across the kitchen and missing steps.

Participant 2A: "my hand was covered in soy sauce and sesame oil and the screen was locked so I couldn't touch it... we missed the exact timing for adding the garlic sauce... we quickly wash our hands to unlock the phone before the pan starts smoking."

Participant 2B: "His hands were oily, so he couldn't even scroll properly. Then everyone was just asking him what's the next step, and we ended up adding one ingredient too early."

Participant 2C: "we were all looking at different recipes... We ended up missing the instructions a bit and added too much seasoning."

This feels like its own distinct problem from the planning issue above. It's specifically about getting hands-free access to instructions mid-task in a messy environment.

Theme 5: Different preferences get avoided rather than worked through

When people want different things, whether that's healthier food versus normal dinner or spending more versus keeping it cheap, the usual response isn't negotiation. People just split off and cook separately.

Participant 2B: "if someone is trying to eat clean or track calories... it would be too troublesome, so they just cook separately." Also: "my housemates want, like, instant noodles because it's cheaper and faster. So in the end, we just cook our own food."

Participant 2C: "if someone is following a really strict diet, then they will probably prepare something separate." Also: "if we cannot agree on how much to spend, then we normally just make our own dinner."

This one matters for the meal decision-making option specifically. Nobody described a painful negotiation over what to cook, they described quietly opting out instead. Budget also seems to drive this more than dietary preference on its own.

Theme 6: Cultural food sharing came up but nobody called it a problem

Participant 2A is Taiwanese and lives with Thai roommates and cooked Taiwanese and Thai inspired dishes with them. So cultural exchange is clearly happening in the background of this data. But nobody, at any point, described it as something frustrating or something they wished an app could help with. It just wasn't framed as a pain point.

That doesn't mean cultural exchange has no value, just that based on this sample it isn't where the friction currently sits.

Theme 7: All three independently suggested basically the same app idea

This is probably the strongest pattern in the whole set. When asked what would help, all three described a very similar concept without being prompted toward it.

Participant 2A: "we can join a session... it will give me a checklist of some specific preparation tasks while their phone will give their task to them... I hope that my phone will ring when it is time to bring the plate over."

Participant 2B: "everyone can join the same cooking session and get their own tasks. My phone could tell me to cut the vegetables, and my friend's phone could tell them to do the chicken... when I finish, I can mark it as done."

Participant 2C: "an app would be quite useful, especially if everyone could see the whole plan in one place... choose the meal, split the cost, assign cooking and cleaning tasks, and see what everyone has already done."

Three separate people landed on something very close to the same feature set: joining a shared session, getting individually assigned tasks, marking progress in real time, and getting notified on timing. For a sample this small, that's a pretty unusual level of agreement.

Pulling it together

Option	How strong is the evidence
Coordination Experience	Strong. Themes 1, 2, 3, 4 and 7 all point here. This is where the actual stress and unfairness live, and it's the only area where participants spontaneously described a solution.
Meal Decision-Making Experience	Weak to moderate. Theme 5 shows disagreement exists, but it gets avoided through separate cooking rather than actually negotiated.
Cultural Sharing Experience	Weak. Present in the data but never mentioned as a barrier or unmet need.

Based on this round of interviews, Option A has the clearest evidence behind it. A tighter version of the opportunity might be something like enhancing how students coordinate task division and timing during collaborative cooking itself, rather than scheduling in general. That keeps the focus on the in-kitchen moment where Themes 3 and 4 point, not just calendar-level planning.

Worth noting this is only three participants, so treat this as a strong direction to test further rather than a final answer.